Some problems, however, persist. Among them is the continuing flow of illegal immigrants from Bangladesh into India. This has been discussed between the two governments on a number of occasions, including at a meeting between the Directors General of the Border Security Force and the Bangladesh Rifles. We have conveyed to Bangladesh our intention to stem this flow by whatever means possible.

Vibhas told me that the R&AW knew the Ershad was getting cosy with the West, particularly with the American intelligence agency which treated the dictator as their best bet against Soviet influence. The CIA was jubilant when the Ershad-led Jatiyo Party won the election in May 1986. The result of the completely rigged polls was already known to the world; however, the CIA insisted that it would provide some legitimacy for Ershad. A CIA report said:

Ershad plans to use pro-government forces in [the] Parliament to pass an amendment ratifying his actions during four years of Martial Law. We expect the amendment to be approved; the leftist Awami League failed to gain the necessary seats to block it. The major opposition party BNP boycotted the polls and plans to pursue a disobedience campaign. The army is unhappy that the pro-government party did not win more seats but will continue its grudging support for Ershad. He was able to pull off the elections after months of wrangling with the Awami League and the BNP. According to the US embassy, Ershad secured Sheikh Hasina's agreement to participate in elections in return for relaxing Martial Law and promising to remain neutral during the elections.

Ershad won one hundred and eighty-three of three hundred seats and despite the noise about the rigged polls, swiftly took